

The ten grains, specced

Every grain with real behaviour: states, interactions, data contract, copy rules, edge cases, and what happens when Emma is off. Click things — the mocks are live. Domains span HR, Payroll, Compliance, Payments and Benefits.

HOW TO READ A SPEC

Confidence is the only variable that changes the shape.

Drag it. Same finding, three geometries. This is the thing to internalise before designing any of the ten — everything else in a grain is content, this is structure.

.96 HIGH

Rejected 4 expenses — alcohol, policy 4.2

Robert, Ana, Lin, Ken · comment attached

Undo · 15s

HIGH · one line, already done. asking for approval here would be the old work with extra reading. the undo is the consent.

What each spec table means

TRIGGER	The signal that creates the grain. If you can't name it, the grain can't exist.
STATES	Every state you have to draw. Includes the ones designers forget: empty, degraded, superseded.
INTERACTION	What is clickable and exactly what happens after. No "opens a modal".
DATA	The fields the component consumes. Anything not listed here cannot appear in the design.
COPY	The claim-bar formula. Sentence case. No "AI has identified".

LIMITS	Height budget, row caps, what happens on overflow.
EDGE	The cases that break the layout. Design these or QA will find them for you.
OFF	What renders when Emma is unavailable. Ship gate question 3.

GRAIN 01

Tension

PAYROLL

LOW CONFIDENCE · TERMINAL · STAMPED · SLOT 1

Two facts contradict each other and the system cannot pick. The only grain that admits ignorance — and the reason people believe the other nine.

TRY

Unresolved

After you answer

Priya Nair is on two payrolls this cycle

Anjil Crafts · New York — semi-monthly, since Jan 2024

\$6,250.00

Anjil Craft Nepal · Kathmandu — monthly, since Aug 1

NPR 180,000

Same work email, same tax ID

p.nair@anjilcrafts.com

Termination on the US record

none

Transferred to Nepal on Aug 1, or a duplicate record?

Transfer — prorate both

Duplicate — pay Nepal only

Ask Priya's manager

THE NARROWEST QUESTION. not "review 2 records" — one sentence, two named readings, three exits. the risk footer is reserved for the unresolved question and nothing else.

REQUIREMENT	
TRIGGER	Two or more beliefs that cannot both be true, where neither has enough evidence to win. Confidence in the winning reading is below .55 . Above that it is a Difference or an Approval, not a Tension.
STATES	Unresolved — evidence expanded, risk footer, 2–3 named exits Resolved — stamped, states what changed, undo available Superseded — someone else resolved it first. Greyed, "Priya's manager answered this at 10:52". Design this one — payroll is multiplayer.

- **Stale** — the underlying records changed after the tension was raised. Must re-verify before acting.

INTERACTION	Each exit resolves in place and re-renders as stamped — no navigation, no modal. "Ask X" sends a message and moves the grain to a <code>waiting</code> variant with the recipient named. Undo restores the unresolved state and reverts the data change.
DATA	<code>claim</code> · <code>confidence</code> · <code>facts[]</code> (2–5 rows, label + value, one may be flagged) · <code>question</code> · <code>readings[]</code> (2–3, each with label + effect) · <code>resolvedBy</code> · <code>resolvedAt</code> · <code>becomesBelief</code>
COPY	Claim = the contradiction with named subjects . "Priya Nair is on two payrolls this cycle" — not "Duplicate payroll record detected". Question = one sentence offering both readings. Never "review", never "detected", never "please".
LIMITS	Max 5 fact rows. Max 3 exits. If it needs 6 facts it is two tensions, or it is a Selection. Height budget ~240px.
EDGE	• Three readings, not two — allowed, but a fourth means the system hasn't reasoned enough • Resolving one tension creates another (transfer → tax residency question) • Both readings have identical financial effect → then it is not a tension, suppress it
OFF	Nothing renders. The two records stay visible in People and Payroll as they always were. Nothing is blocked.

GRAIN 02

Difference HR

HIGH · TERMINAL · LIVE · SLOT 2

What moved against a stated baseline. This is what replaced the summary card — and the baseline is not optional.

BASELINE

Since last payroll

Since Monday

Nothing changed

4 things changed in People since you last approved payroll

LIVE

New hires · Barcelona — start Sep 1	+2
David Wilson · Analyst — comp change approved by Priya	+8%
Emily Jones — resignation, last day Aug 29	final pay due
Kinsley Harrell — title change, no comp change	no payroll effect

THE BASELINE IS IN PROVENANCE, ALWAYS. "since Friday" in the claim and "vs your approval on Aug 6 14:12" underneath. a difference against an unnamed baseline is a summary.

REQUIREMENT

TRIGGER	Any delta against exactly one of three legal baselines: prior state (last visit, last approval), expected policy (comp band, budget line), intended plan (headcount plan, forecast). A delta against nothing is a summary — suppress it.
STATES	• Populated — 1 to 6 rows, ranked by payroll impact • Empty — states the baseline and the scan count. Never hidden. • Overflow — more than 6 changes → top 5 plus "and 11 more →" as the door • Baseline missing — first-ever session, no prior state. Renders as "First time here — nothing to compare against yet."
INTERACTION	Rows are not individually clickable — a Difference reports, it does not act. The action exit converts the difference into the next grain (usually Consequence: "what does this cost?"). Baseline is not user-switchable in production; it is chosen by context.
DATA	<code>baseline {type, label, timestamp} · scannedCount · changes [] {label, delta, direction, payrollEffect: bool} · overflowCount</code>
COPY	<code>{n} things changed in {scope} since {baseline}</code> . Rows read as sentences, not fields: "David Wilson · Analyst — comp change approved by Priya" not "comp_change: 8%". Zero state: "Nothing changed in {scope} since {baseline}."
LIMITS	Max 6 rows, then overflow. Height budget ~220px. Row labels truncate at one line — never wrap to three.
EDGE	• A change with no payroll effect (title change) — include it, mark it "no payroll effect". Omitting it makes the user re-check manually. • A change that reverses a previous change within the window → collapse to net, show "changed twice" in provenance • Baseline is more than 60 days old → say so; a stale baseline makes the count meaningless
OFF	The People list renders as it always has, with its own sort and filters. No change indicator.

and it must show the message being sent on the user's behalf.

TRY

Before

Sent — undo running

Settled

Pay 23 contractors — \$47,180 across 4 currencies

— .93

USD · 12 people	\$28,400.00
EUR · 6 people · Barcelona	€9,200.00
NPR · 3 people · Kathmandu	NPR 1,240,000
GBP · 2 people	£3,100.00
Funding — Anjil Crafts operating account	confirmed

FX locked 09:00 Aug 17 · reversible until the 16:00 cutoff

Pay 23

Review one by one

FX LOCK AND CUTOFF LIVE IN PROVENANCE. the user is consenting to a rate and a deadline as much as to an amount. both belong above the button, not in a tooltip.

REQUIREMENT

TRIGGER

Emma has prepared an action with financial or personnel consequence and confidence is **.6–.95**. Above .95 with low blast radius it collapses to a High-density Difference with an undo. Below .6 it is a Tension.

STATES

- **Before** — what, to whom, at what rate, with what message attached
- **Sending** — live undo counter, explicit "nothing has left yet"
- **Settled** — stamped, with partial-failure breakdown
- **Partially failed** — the state everyone forgets. Never a red toast; it is a state of this grain with its own exit.
- **Expired** — the cutoff passed before the user answered. Must say what happens next cycle.
- **Blocked** — funding not confirmed, or RBAC denies. Shows who can approve it.

INTERACTION

Primary commits and immediately enters Sending with a counter. Counter reaching zero transitions to Settled without further input. Cancel reverts to Before with a note that it was cancelled. "Review one by one" is a **door** — it hands off to the payments screen with the batch preselected.

DATA

action · subjects[] · total + currencies[] · attachedMessage (if any) · fxLock {rate, at} · cutoff · undoSeconds · fundingStatus · batchId · results {settled, returned[]}

COPY	Verb first, count, total: Pay 23 contractors — \$47,180 across 4 currencies . If a message goes to a person, show it verbatim — the user is consenting to words a colleague will read. Never "Are you sure?".
LIMITS	Group by currency/entity/reason, never list 23 people. Max 6 summary rows. If the user needs the list, that is the door.
EDGE	• Partial failure — the single most important state in the whole language. Design it first. • FX moves between render and commit → re-confirm, do not silently re-price • Someone else approves it mid-undo → collapse to Superseded, name them • User's RBAC allows preparing but not approving → Blocked state naming the approver
OFF	The payments screen with its existing bulk-pay flow, unchanged. Slower, still correct.

GRAIN 04

Consequence

PAYROLL · BENEFITS

ANY CONFIDENCE · TERMINAL · LIVE · ADJACENT TO A DECISION

What this decision does downstream, before it is made, recalculating as the user changes their mind. Replaces "Are you sure?" — which transfers anxiety without transferring information.

TOGGLE THE DECISION the grain recalculates live

Approving 3 changes moves Friday's run by \$4,062

LIVE

✓ David Wilson — 8% raise, effective Aug 1	+\$1,534
✓ 2 Barcelona hires — prorated from Sep 1	+\$2,100
✓ Emily Jones — final pay and accrued leave	+\$428
Payroll total · Aug 21	\$251,406 → \$255,468
401(k) employer match · annualised	+\$1,224
David moves above the Analyst band ceiling	by \$4,100
Nepal entity funding buffer	falls to 2.4 days

FX at Aug 17 09:00 · buffer assumes no other outflows

Approve selected

Exclude Nepal

TWO DIMENSIONS MINIMUM, ONE THAT GOT WORSE. the band breach and the funding buffer are why the second exit exists. a consequence panel showing only upside is a reward screen, and people stop reading it by the third time.

REQUIREMENT	
TRIGGER	Any decision with second-order effects the user cannot see from the primary object. Never rendered on its own — always adjacent to an Approval or a Selection.
STATES	Live — recalculating, debounced ~250ms Nothing selected — "Nothing selected — no effect" with the baseline still shown Uncomputable — a dimension can't be calculated (FX feed down). Say which one is missing, never silently drop the row. All-upside — genuinely no downside. Must state that explicitly: "Nothing gets worse." Silence reads as hiding.
INTERACTION	Selection controls live inside the grain. Every toggle updates the claim bar and all dimension rows. Rows are read-only. The secondary exit exists to relieve the worst dimension — its label names that dimension ("Exclude Nepal"), it is not a generic "Cancel".
DATA	<code>options[] {label, amount, key, selected} · dimensions[] {label, from, to, direction, computable} · assumptions[] → provenance · relieverExit {label, removesKey}</code>
COPY	<code>{Action} moves {thing} by {delta}</code> in the claim bar, recalculating. Dimension labels are outcomes not metrics: "David moves above the Analyst band ceiling" not "Band compliance: fail".
LIMITS	2–4 dimensions. Max 5 toggles. More toggles means this is a Selection with a Consequence attached, not one grain.
EDGE	- A dimension improves for one entity and worsens for another — show both rows, never net them - Recalc takes over ~600ms → show the previous value greyed, never a spinner over the number - An assumption expires mid-session (FX lock) → the whole grain goes stamped and asks to refresh
OFF	Nothing. The approval proceeds with today's confirmation dialog. Consequence is additive — this is the cleanest gate-3 pass in the set.

GRAIN 05

Selection

COMPLIANCE

HIGH · TERMINAL · LIVE · SLOT 2

A ranked subset with visible reasoning and a visible bottom. Replaces bulk-select, which makes the human do the classification.

7 of 148 people have a document expiring before the next run

.89

Work authorisation expires in under 30 days — blocks payroll	3
I-9 reverification overdue	2
Nepal SSF registration missing — new entity	2

ranked by payroll-blocking × days to expiry · 148 scanned

Start with the 3 blockers

Open compliance →

THE BOTTOM IS THE POINT. 141 people were deliberately set aside and the reasons are inspectable. a ranking you cannot argue with does not get trusted twice — and "7 need review" with no visible bottom is a badge count.

REQUIREMENT	
TRIGGER	A set larger than roughly 20 where a minority needs attention and the ranking function is explainable in one line. If you cannot write the ranking function, ship a filter instead — that is the product's job.
STATES	• Ranked — reasons on top, deprioritised collapsed but present • Expanded — the bottom, with counts and reasons • All clear — "148 scanned, none expiring before the next run." Still shows the deprioritisation reasons. • Low confidence — below .7 the grain must say what it might be missing: "I can't read 4 documents — they're scanned images." • Partially scanned — a source was unreachable. State the gap, never present a partial scan as complete.
INTERACTION	Reason rows are clickable and narrow the grain in place to that reason — they do not navigate. Primary exit starts a queue through the top reason one at a time. The door hands off with the same ranking applied as a saved view, so the user is not re-filtering by hand.
DATA	<code>scannedCount</code> · <code>rankingFunction</code> (human-readable) · <code>groups[]</code> {reason, count, blocking: bool} · <code>deprioritised[]</code> {reason, count} · <code>unscannable</code> {count, why}
COPY	<code>{n}</code> of <code>{total}</code> <code>{noun}</code> <code>{condition}</code> . Blocking groups say so inline. Deprioritised rows state the reason not the rule id: "Valid for more than 6 months" not "rule COMP-14 passed".
LIMITS	Max 4 active groups, max 4 deprioritised. Height budget ~200px collapsed, ~300px expanded. Never render individual people — that is the door.

EDGE

- A person appears in two groups → count once, in the higher-severity group, and say so in provenance
- Everything is blocking (7 of 7 urgent) → the ranking added nothing; say "all 7 block payroll" rather than faking a hierarchy
- The deprioritised list is empty because nothing was excluded → hide the expander, do not show an empty tray

OFF

The compliance table with its existing status filters. The saved view produced by the ranking stays available — it is data, not AI.

GRAIN 06

Draft

BENEFITS

MED · TRANSITIONAL · STAMPED · IN THREAD

Emma does the boring majority and hands off. The grain that keeps long forms out of the thread — and the fix for the summary-card height problem.

TRY

Prepared

Source changed

Benefits enrolment prepared for 2 Barcelona hires — 11 of 14 fields

DRAFT

Copied from your Spain plan defaults — Sanitas Plan B

11 fields

Dependants — no records on file

NEEDS YOU

Plan tier — Standard or Plus

NEEDS YOU

Effective date — hire date or 1st of month

NEEDS YOU

draft saved · nothing submitted · enrolment window closes Sep 15

Finish in Benefits →

ONE EXIT, AND IT IS A DOOR. a legally-binding 14-field enrolment does not become chat inputs. the grain reports what was prepared, what is left, and where it came from — then gets out of the way.

REQUIREMENT

TRIGGER

A form or multi-step task where Emma can fill $\geq 50\%$ from existing records, and the remainder needs human judgment, legal attestation, or data the system does not hold. Below 50% prefilled, just open the form.

STATES

- **Prepared** — filled count, source, what's left, deadline

- **Stale** — a source record changed since preparation. Names the change and the affected field count.
- **Resumed** — user returned from the screen partway. Shows remaining count only.
- **Completed** — stamped, "submitted by you on X", collapses to one line
- **Expired** — the window closed. States the consequence, offers the next window.

INTERACTION **One exit only, and it is the door.** No inline editing, ever — the moment a field is editable here it is a form in a thread. The door carries draft state and lands on the first unfilled field, not the top of the form.

DATA `filled / total` · `sources[] {label, fieldCount}` · `needsUser[] {label, why}` · `deadline` · `draftId` · `preparedAt` · `sourceVersion` (for staleness)

COPY `{Task} prepared for {subject} – {n} of {total} fields` . Every NEEDS YOU row says **why** it needs a human: "no records on file", not "required". Provenance always includes "nothing submitted".

LIMITS Max 5 rows. Height budget ~200px. If the remaining list exceeds 5, say "and 6 more" — the door is the answer, not a taller card.

EDGE

- Draft is for multiple subjects with divergent needs → one grain, but say "2 people, different tiers needed"
- User completes it directly on the screen without returning → grain must detect and collapse to Completed, not linger as a draft
- Deadline passes while the draft is open → Expired state, never a silent failure

OFF The benefits enrolment form, empty, exactly as it works today.

GRAIN 07

Evidence

PAYMENTS

ANY · TERMINAL · STAMPED · IN THREAD

A document set against the record that disagrees with it. Never a viewer on its own — if there is no claim about the document, the user is doing the reading we were supposed to do.

The invoice says €7,400. The payment request is €8,140.

— .81

INVOICE · INV-2291 · GRÁFICAS BCN

Subtotal	€6,116.00
IVA 21%	€1,284.00
Total	€7,400.00

PAYMENT REQUEST · PR-1180

Amount	€8,140.00
Difference	+€740.00
Equals 10% of subtotal	rush fee?

OCR .81 · totals line is handwritten · no
second invoice attached

Pay €7,400

Ask Gráficas BCN

Open invoice

THE ARITHMETIC IS THE ARGUMENT. €740 is exactly 10% of the subtotal — naming that pattern is what turns a mismatch into a hypothesis the user can confirm in one glance. never show two documents and let them do the subtraction.

REQUIREMENT

TRIGGER	An extracted value disagrees with a recorded value by more than the tolerance for that document type. No disagreement, no grain — a matching invoice is silence, not a green tick.
STATES	• Mismatch — side by side, difference named, hypothesis offered • Unreadable — OCR below .5. Says what it could not read and shows the document. Never guesses. • Missing document — request with no invoice. "No invoice attached" is a claim. • Multi-document — two invoices for one request. Shows the sum and whether it reconciles. • Resolved — stamped with which figure was paid and why
INTERACTION	Primary pays the evidenced figure, never the requested one — the default sides with the document. "Ask {vendor}" opens a prefilled message with the discrepancy quoted. "Open invoice" is the door to the full document viewer.
DATA	<code>document {id, vendor, lines[], total, ocrConfidence, flags[]} · record {id, amount} · difference · hypothesis (nullable) · tolerance</code>
COPY	Two sentences, both concrete: <code>The invoice says X. The request is Y.</code> The hypothesis is phrased as a question — "rush fee?" — never as a finding. We are 81% sure of the number, not of the reason.
LIMITS	Max 4 lines per document. Long line items truncate. Height budget ~260px. Full document is always the door.

EDGE

- Currency differs between document and record → the FX rate becomes a third column, not a footnote
- Difference is within tolerance but the vendor is new → not an Evidence grain; that's a Question
- Handwriting or a photo of a screen → drop confidence hard and say why in provenance

OFF

The payment request with its attachment link, as today. The user opens the PDF and does the subtraction themselves.

GRAIN 08

Insight

BENEFITS

MED · TRANSITIONAL · LIVE · SLOT 2 OR THREAD

A pattern over time with a stated so-what. The only grain allowed a chart — and the chart never carries the finding.

TRY

Finding

Modelled alternative

Coverage waivers doubled after the May plan change — 31% of US staff now decline

LIVE



The May switch raised the employee premium share from 10% to 25%. Waivers went from 14% to 31% — **18 people** now hold no coverage, and a waiver rate above 30% weakens your group rating at the January renewal.

94 US employees · monthly, enrolment records · excludes contractors

Model a 15% share

Open benefits →

THE CHART SHOWS SHAPE, THE CLAIM CARRIES THE POINT. one series, monochrome, only the post-change months highlighted. if someone has to read the chart to learn the finding, the claim bar failed.

REQUIREMENT

TRIGGER

A trend that crosses a threshold, changes slope after a known event, or implies a deadline. A trend with no so-what is a dashboard tile — not a grain.

STATES

- **Finding** — measured series, cause attributed if known
- **Modelled** — hatched projection, lower confidence, "not a quote"
- **Insufficient history** — fewer than 6 periods. Say so; do not draw a trend through 3 points.

- **Reversed** — the trend corrected since last render. Must acknowledge rather than quietly disappear.

INTERACTION	Bars are not interactive — no tooltips, no drill-down. The action exit runs a model and swaps the series in place. The door opens the real analytics screen. Everything more precise than "shape" belongs behind the door.
DATA	<code>series[] {period, value} · highlightFrom · cause {event, date, attribution} · threshold · soWhat · population {count, exclusions} · modelled {from, confidence}</code>
COPY	Claim contains the direction, the magnitude, and the consequence . "Coverage waivers doubled after the May plan change — 31% now decline". Never a neutral title. Never "trending upward".
LIMITS	One series only. 8–14 points. No legend, no axis values, no second colour. Two lines of prose max under the chart. Height budget ~250px.
EDGE	• Two plausible causes → name both, or name none. Attributing one cause you are not sure of is the fastest way to lose an executive's trust. • The population changed mid-series (headcount grew) → use a rate, and say the denominator moved • Seasonal pattern misread as a trend → require ≥1 prior cycle before claiming a change
OFF	The benefits analytics page with its existing charts and filters.

GRAIN 09

Basis

COMPLIANCE

ANY · TERMINAL · STAMPED · PULLED, NEVER PUSHED

Where a belief came from. This is the only grain the user summons — rendering every source next to every claim makes a thread unreadable by the fourth answer.

TRY

The claim alone

After "why?"

Michael Brown is owed 6.5 hours of overtime this week

— .92

Hours logged · week of Aug 11 · San Francisco

47.5 h

Overtime at 1.5×

6.5 h · \$487.50

CA · timesheet TS-3390 · approved by his manager

Why?

Open timesheet →

THE BASIS IS NOT RENDERED YET. a "why?" affordance on every claim, and the source appears only when asked. this is the difference between a defensible system and an

REQUIREMENT

TRIGGER	User request only. Never auto-renders. Every claim in the system carries a "why?" affordance; this is what appears behind it.
STATES	• Collapsed — the affordance only, on the parent grain • Expanded — quote, then the facts that trigger it • Multi-source — a rule plus a company policy plus a contract term. Ordered by precedence, and the precedence is stated. • Stale source — the regulation changed after the belief formed. Highest-severity state in the grain: show both versions. • No source — the belief is statistical, not rule-based. Must say "this is a pattern, not a rule" rather than inventing a citation.
INTERACTION	Expands inside the parent grain, does not spawn a sibling. Collapse restores. The door opens the policy or regulation library. No copy button, no share — this is for the person deciding right now.
DATA	<code>sources[] {type: regulation policy contract, citation, quote, effectiveFrom, syncedAt, precedence} · triggeringFacts[] {label, value, breaches: bool} · preemptedObjection</code>
COPY	Quote is verbatim and unedited — ellipsis for length, never paraphrase. Provenance carries citation, sync date, and which rule variant applied ("daily rule, not weekly").
LIMITS	One quote, max ~45 words. Max 5 triggering facts. Multiple sources stack to a max of 3. Height budget ~300px expanded — the largest in the set, and the only one allowed to be.
EDGE	• Sources conflict (state vs company policy) → show both, state which wins and why. Never silently pick. • Jurisdiction is ambiguous (remote worker, two states) → that is a Tension, not a Basis • Rule changed between the belief and the request → both versions, both dates, recompute
OFF	The policy library and the timesheet detail page, both reachable by navigation as today.

GRAIN 10

Question

PAYMENTS

LOW · TERMINAL · LIVE · MAX ONE PER SESSION

One question, asked once, remembered forever. Replaces the settings page — intent captured at the moment it matters, then reused as an editable belief.

Fourth time this quarter — should contractor invoices under \$500 approve themselves?

.29

Under \$500, approved by you, last 90 days	23 of 24
Rejected — a duplicate from Gráficas BCN	1
Median time you spent on each	11 seconds

becomes a rule in Policies · editable, revocable, logged

Auto-approve under \$500

Keep asking me

Not now

THE EVIDENCE IS WHY IT IS ALLOWED TO ASK. 23 of 24 and 11 seconds each — without those rows this is an onboarding survey. "not now" is a real answer and must not re-ask for 30 days.

REQUIREMENT

TRIGGER

The system has seen the **same decision ≥3 times** with a consistent outcome and holds no rule for it. Requires observed evidence — never asked pre-emptively, never during onboarding.

STATES

- **Asked** — evidence, 2–3 options, what happens to the answer
- **Belief created** — stamped rule with its exceptions and estimated effect
- **Deferred** — "not now". Silent for 30 days minimum; on return it must say "I asked in August".
- **Contradicted** — the user acts against their own rule. The grain returns and asks whether the rule should change. **Design this.**
- **Revoked** — rule turned off. States what starts coming back.

INTERACTION

Answering resolves in place to the belief state. Undo removes the rule entirely. **Max one Question grain per session** — two is an interrogation, and a system that interrogates gets dismissed.

DATA

`pattern {occurrences, window, consistency} · evidence[] · options[] (2–3, one always "keep asking") · becomes {ruleLocation, scope, exceptions[]} · estimatedEffect · deferUntil`

COPY

Open with the count: `Fourth time this quarter – should {behaviour}?`. Always phrase as a question the user could answer out loud. The belief state names **exceptions before benefits**.

LIMITS

3 evidence rows, 3 options. Height budget ~200px. Never two questions in one grain.

EDGE

- The user's pattern is **inconsistent** (12 approved, 12 rejected) → do not ask. There is no belief to capture, only noise.
- Answering creates a rule that conflicts with an existing one → surface the conflict as a Tension instead of stacking rules
- Multiple people share the account → a rule set by one person must name its author everywhere it fires

OFF

The Policies settings page. Every rule this grain creates must be visible and editable there — the grain is a shortcut into settings, never a replacement for them.

SHELL

Your Floater, aligned

The Floater isn't a separate component in this language — it is the **Shell at line density**, docked to a page, hosting exactly one grain. Which grain depends on what was found.

What's there now

Found 3 Suspicious Expense Items

View



Ask anything about expenses

PROBLEM	WHY IT MATTERS
COUNT	"Found 3 suspicious items" is a count, not a claim. It tells you how much, never whether it matters. Three \$12 duplicates and three \$9,000 forgeries render identically.
NO BASIS	Suspicious <i>why</i> ? Without a reason the user must open it to learn anything, so the floater has cost them a click and told them nothing.
NO CONFIDENCE	Nothing to calibrate against. After one wrong flag, every future flag is discounted equally.
NO ACTION	[View] is a door with no action beside it. Every finding requires a trip to another screen even when the answer is obvious.
CHROMA	Purple glow, purple button, purple sparkle. Violates the color law — AI has no hue, and in an ambient palette this competes with the brand instead of standing out.

CASE

"Found 3 Suspicious Expense Items" is title case. Niural is sentence case.

Aligned

STATES

Found something

Can't tell

All clear

Emma off

3 expenses break policy 4.2 — \$9,240, all from one team

312 scanned · alcohol on receipt · prepared, not sent

Reject 3

See them →

Ask about expenses

↑

ONE COMPONENT, FOUR STATES. the claim bar changes grain type by situation; the prompt bar never moves. with Emma off it degrades to the search bar the page already had — gate question 3, passed.

REQUIREMENT

ROLE

Shell at **line density**. It is not a component — it is a dock. Exactly one grain lives in it at a time.

WHICH GRAIN

Confidence and situation pick it, not the designer: contradiction → **Tension** · found a set → **Selection** · already acted → **Difference** with undo · nothing found → **Difference**, empty state. The dock never renders a bespoke shape.

STATES

- **Scanning** — process layer only, no claim bar, no count
- **Found** — grain at line or card density
- **All clear** — a claim, with the primary action still offered
- **Acted** — collapses to one line with a live undo
- **Emma off** — the page's own search bar, unstyled. Nothing missing.

GROWTH

Grows upward from the prompt bar, which stays anchored. Max height ~40% of viewport — past that it is the sheet density, which is a different surface. Never covers the row the user is looking at.

COPY

Sentence case. Claim contains a **consequence or a magnitude**, never a bare count. "3 expenses break policy 4.2 — \$9,240, all from one team" is the bar to clear.

NEVER

No purple glow, no gradient, no sparkle. No "Found N items". No [View] as the only exit. No auto-expand while the user is typing or scrolling.

The Emma panel and the AI filter chip

WHAT	VERDICT
EMMA PANEL	The insight card is prose where a grain belongs. "The AI has identified some suspicious expenses that require your attention" is throat-clearing; "the claimed amount does not align with expected costs" states a mismatch without stating either number. It has no action, no confidence, no basis — and \$155.16 is green, which in this system means settled . Becomes: an Evidence grain — receipt total against claimed total, difference named, [Approve \$X] and [Ask Robert].
FILTER CHIP	Closest thing to right in the set — a filter is honest about being a filter. Two fixes: drop the purple border and the sparkle (it is a filter, not a personality), and label the result not the mechanism. Suspicious expense · 3 of 312 beats AI Filter Suspicious Expense . Keep the x.
SMART ACTIONS	"Smart Actions by Niural AI" with an info icon is a label for a container. Containers don't get names. The actions belong in the grain's footer, where their consequence is visible.

Grain · ten grains, specced · draft for team review

States marked **Design this** are the ones that break first in production: partial failure, superseded, stale source, contradicted rule.